

Bajaj did react with the Pulsar in 2001—which went on to become the highest-selling model in the above-125cc segment—but it could not reclaim leadership in the entry-level segment. Currently, the 100cc segment is the turf of Hero MotoCorp, whereas Honda Motorcycle & Scooter India dominates in 125cc.

With the Freedom 125, priced at ₹1.1 lakh, Bajaj is trying to grab back a slice of the entry-level segment with a technology that can potentially become a game changer. “The message from Freedom 30 years later is *Tiger Zinda Hai* (Tiger is alive),” Bajaj said.

Bajaj Auto claims that, unlike its ICE counterparts, the Freedom 125 reduces fuel expenses by 50%. The 2-kg CNG cylinder and 2-litre petrol tank provide a combined range of 330 km. Moreover, the cost per km is only ₹1 for CNG, while it is ₹2.25 for petrol. According to Rakesh Sharma, Executive Director at Bajaj Auto, the hybrid CNG fuel tank will help customers save up to ₹1,500 per month.

Analysts observe that the motorcycle will find a niche amongst consumers who have easy access to CNG pumps. “It will especially appeal to those who are highly conscious of fuel costs and are willing to invest the time in filling up CNG, which typically costs less than petrol,” says Anurag Singh, MD of consulting firm Primus Partners.

Bajaj Auto is hoping to recreate the stellar gains it has seen in the three-wheeler CNG segment, where it commands a 70% market share.

The company will roll out the first 1,000 units of Freedom 125 beginning next quarter in Maharashtra and Gujarat.

A major hurdle would be the lack of CNG infrastructure and a single CNG pump in gas stations. Bajaj Auto says that it has partnered with oil marketing companies to set up CNG pumps. **BT**

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